

First real step in second chapter is unlearning”

RAJU MISTRY

Former Global CHRO at Grasim, Jubilant, and Cipla

EVEN AFTER LEAVING a demanding corporate career, Raju Mistry found that she had not quite left its routines behind.

“The 9-to-9 rhythm is so deeply embedded that it took me a couple of months to realize I could begin and end my workday whenever I chose,” says Mistry, former President and Global Chief Human Resources Officer at Grasim, Jubilant, and Cipla, who founded Aarunyam Behavioural Specialists LLP.

“Unlearning that was the first real step in my second chapter.”

A corporate career, she says, can become all-consuming, with power equations and egos diverting creative energy and taking a toll on health.

“Entrepreneurship offers the opposite: freedom, autonomy, and the chance to build something that is truly yours. Starting from the ground up demands patience, courage, and conviction, but that is exactly the thrill of it,” she says.

Aarunyam, a dream she had nurtured, became a reality at the beginning of this year. The venture has given her a new professional purpose, while the change in routine has created room for interests that were harder to accommodate during her corporate career.

Mistry’s reflections on reinvention extend to lessons she learnt while building her career. Early on, she resisted generalist roles because she believed she lacked the experience to move beyond her specialist background. Mentors and bosses encouraged her to broaden her exposure, eventually opening the way to senior HR leadership positions.

“Today we’d call that imposter syndrome,” she says.

Mistry believes the conversation around women’s access to board positions needs to move beyond comparisons between men and women. Expectations around gender, she says, begin in childhood and are reinforced through socialisation, shaping the choices and experiences people carry into their careers.

She also sees a shift in how women approach board opportunities. Rather than waiting to be considered, many are now in a position to choose the organisations they want to serve.

“What I find most striking is that women today have the luxury of choice. They are deciding which companies they want to serve, rather than waiting to be chosen,” she says. Digital communication platforms have further widened access to professional networks.

For Mistry, reinvention is about building a more fulfilling way of working and living. BT